

the cameras in this category allowed for manually setting the metering mode. The Nikon CoolPix 800 stood out here—there was no other camera that allowed the level of freedom in choosing and manually setting the various imaging parameters as this one.

Memory: All the cameras in the sub-2.0 megapixel category included 8 MB of memory. Some of them like the D-Link DSC-350, the Benq DC 300 and the Kodak EasyShare DX3215 have the memory integrated into the device, while the others were based upon the Smart Media or Compact Flash format. They all stored images in JPEG format with the exception of the D-Link DSC-350, which stored images in BMP format. Five out of the seven cameras supported Web cam capability—a definite thumbs up for home users.

In the 2+ megapixel category, the majority of cameras bundled 8 MB of either Smart Media or Compact Flash-based memory systems. The exceptions were Fuji FinePix 2800, FinePix A201 and Nikon CoolPix 775, which bundled 16 MB of memory. Interestingly, the Kodak EasyShare DX3600 integrated its 8 MB of memory in the camera itself, with an option of upgrading it via a



Casio GV-10

The Casio GV-10 completely revolutionises the perception of a digital camera being delicate and fragile.

There are rubber-lined enclosures for the delicate components and the circuitry inside is encased in a special gel. The company claims that it is resistant to water even if immersed to a depth of 1 metre for 30 minutes and if sprayed from all directions. It is also dust-resistant.

This 1.23 megapixel camera features a 2.5x digital zoom, a 1.6-inch TFT screen, the ability to record video clips and has 8 MB of Compact Flash memory. This camera creates photos at a native resolution of 1280x960 but a software mode hikes this up to 1600x1200 by using interpolation. The 'Best Shot' mode has a set of 18 scenes stored in the camera—you can choose the one that most closely matches the scene you want to shoot and the camera takes care of adjusting all other parameters such as exposure, flash mode and metering. The bundled software detects when the camera has been connected via its USB interface and automatically transfers images from the camera to your computer. This camera is sturdily built and offers a decent set of features.

Price: Rs 26,995

- + Resistant to water and dust, very intuitive method of shooting photos through the 'Best Shot' mode
- No optical zoom, uses software interpolation to obtain its highest resolution

Casio GV-10		B
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Warranty & support	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Compact Flash interface. The Sony CyberShot DSC-P31 expectedly used Sony's own proprietary Memory Stick format.

Ergonomics

Since cameras are meant to be carried around, they are going to spend a large part of their useable life in your palm. Therefore, it becomes very important that the construction and the implementation of the various features is simple, intuitive and comfortable to use. This depends on the way the camera's body is moulded, the placement of the buttons and of course, its size and weight.

In the sub-2.0 megapixel category, the Logitech 510 was the smallest and lightest camera, followed closely by the Olympus Camedia C-1. The largest camera was the Kodak EasyShare DX3215. Also it has a protruding lens barrel, which makes it uncomfortable to carry.

One of the most commendable cameras as far as navigating and understanding the menu goes, was the Kodak EasyShare DX3215 Zoom. It featured the most colourful and easy-to-understand menu and the large icons made it very simple to understand what each menu function means. On the other hand, the Casio GV-10 had many buttons scattered on the top and back panel and it takes some getting used to it.

All of the cameras came with a wrist strap bundled as standard equipment. A worthy mention here is the Casio GV-10. With its tough body and rubber grips, it



Maximising Memory Performance

The storage medium that most cameras use is of the Flash memory type. This technology provides for storage capacities ranging from 4 MB all the way to 512 MB. Flash memory is a great choice because it is available in very small form factors and is able to hold information even after the equipment is switched off. However, this technology does not come cheap. You can expect to spend about Rs 10,000 for a 64 MB Flash memory card.

There are three primary types of Flash memory in use today with digital cameras based on their form factor:

Smart Media: The main advantage with this format is size. The card is about as thin as a cellular phone SIM card and is a little over 1 square inch in size.

Compact Flash: Here, the packaging of the Flash memory is considerably more robust and is about the same breadth and width as the Smart Media, except that it is thicker due to the plastic packaging.

Memory Stick: This is a proprietary Flash memory format that is propounded and used by Sony products and is about the size of half a stick of chewing gum.

Since all forms of flash memory are delicate, you have to take care that they last and deliver error-free performance. In Smart Media, the contacts are exposed and therefore it is important to see that they are free from dirt and scratches. Store these cards in their plastic jackets to prevent damage. Do not subject them to undue physical shock and store them away from extremes in temperature, humidity and moisture.

The best way to fully utilise the storage capacity in these devices is to control the resolution at which you take your photos. Digital cameras allow you to change the image resolution on the fly. Therefore, if you want to pack in more images, use only as large a resolution as you require and allot smaller resolutions to images that are less important.